Questions for product managers

Design Gurus

Most interviews end with "Do you have any questions for me?" Many candidates treat that as the interview being over. At a lot of companies it is still being scored.

Why it counts

Two things happen in these last five minutes.

The interviewer learns how much you have thought about the work. A question you could have answered from the careers page suggests you did not prepare. A question about how the team makes decisions suggests you are already thinking about working there.

You also learn whether you want the job. This is the only part of the process designed for you to gather information, and it is worth using properly. You are choosing too.

What makes a question good

A good question asks about something specific and cannot be answered in one word.

Compare "Is the team collaborative?" with "How does the team decide between two competing technical approaches?" The first invites the answer yes. The second produces a real description of how the team works, and the answer is useful whichever way it goes.

Three or four questions is enough. Ask the ones you actually want answered.

Questions about the work

1. What is the team working on now, and what will it be working on in six months?
2. What do the first ninety days look like for someone in this role?
3. Which part of the system causes the team the most trouble?
4. How do you decide between two competing technical approaches?
5. How much of the team's time goes to new work compared with maintenance?

Question 5 is worth asking everywhere. The answer is rarely rehearsed, and it tells you a great deal about what the job is actually like.

Questions about how the team works

6. How does code review work here, and how long does a change usually take to merge?
7. What does on-call look like, and how often does someone get paged at night?
8. What does the team do after an incident?
9. How are technical decisions recorded?
10. What happened the last time someone disagreed with a plan?

Questions about growth

11. What separates someone doing well in this role from someone doing very well?
12. How does promotion work here, and who decides?
13. What have people who joined at my level gone on to do?
14. What support is there for learning something the team does not already know?

Questions for the hiring manager

15. What is the biggest problem you are hoping this hire will solve?
16. What would make you consider this hire a success after a year?
17. How is the team's work chosen, and how much does the team influence it?
18. What is the one thing about this team you would most like to change?

Question 18 is the most useful on this list. A manager who answers it honestly is telling you what you would be joining. A manager who says nothing needs changing has told you something as well.

Read the answers

Listen for whether the answer is specific. A vague answer to a specific question is information.

If you ask how long a change takes to merge and hear "it depends", ask again with a number attached. "Roughly a day, or roughly a week?" You will usually get an honest answer. It is one of the better predictors of what the work will feel like.

What not to ask

Do not ask anything already answered on the job posting or the company website. It is the one question that actively costs you.

Leave salary, holiday and remote-work policy for the recruiter, unless the interviewer raises them first. Those are fair questions, and this is the wrong room for them.

Do not ask how you did. It puts the interviewer in an awkward position, and the answer will not be honest.

If there is no time left

If the interviewer is short of time, ask one question, then ask who you can send the others to. That is a better outcome than rushing three questions and hearing none of the answers.